An introduction to the Dutch LaTeX document classes*

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3 September 1989

1 Background

The Dutch LaTeX document classes are an attempt to provide LaTeX users with facilities of the standard distribution document classes 'article' and 'report', but coupled to typography that is geared towards Dutch usage. In order to ensure interchangeability, the new styles implemented the commands of the distribution styles. In principle, then, no manual for these styles would be needed. There are a few points, however, that can't go without comment.

Table 1 lists all files connected with the Dutch document classes. These files can be found on the `tex-nl` fileserver on the `hearn` node of Bitnet/Earn and on the CTAN. Not all of them are necessary, the ones with extension `.tex` contain just blah.

Remark: there exists a Dutch version of 'letter', which is so specifically Dutch that I decided not to include it in this list.

`ntgclass.tex`	The LaTeX 2_ε source for this text
`ntgclass.dtx`	The source for all the class files
`ntgclass.dst`	A docstrip program to produce the class files from the source.
`artikel1.cls`	article compatible, design 1, straightforward
`artikel2.cls`	article compatible, design 2, rather different
`artikel3.cls`	article compatible, design 3, parskip instead of indent
`rapport1.cls`	report compatible, design 1
`rapport3.cls`	report compatible, design 3
`book.cls`	book compatible, design 1
`ntg10.clo`	10 point option for all styles
`ntg11.clo`	11 point option for all styles
`ntg12.clo`	12 point option for all styles
`artdoc.tex`	the genesis of the 'artikel' classes, in Dutch
`briefdoc.tex`	the genesis of the 'brief class, also in Dutch
`rapdoc.tex`	the genesis of the 'rapport' classes, also in Dutch.

Table 1: List of files

* Updated for LaTeX 2_ε by Johannes Braams, 6 february 1994

2 Languages

These styles have been developed bearing in mind suggestions of Hubert Partl for making the language of styles switchable. Thus, on their own these styles will produce English captions like 'chapter' and 'table of contents', but specifying the options 'dutch' or 'german', or any language option that follows the directions of Partl, will switch these to the language of the option.

3 Design

At the moment there are styles compatible with 'article' and with 'report'. The Dutch names for these are 'artikel' and 'rapport'. In contrast to the standard styles, however, the user can now choose from different visual designs. Names of the styles are formed by appending their number to the name, for instance 'rapport3'.

1. Design one is meant to be a universally acceptable style. It has been kept as uncontroversial as possible. Under heavy protests of the implementer (me) the one point that has turned out to be controversial, the table of contents, has been made subject to a switch that can restore the old LaTeX layout. Explanation of this follows.
2. Design two will probably never be heavily used. It is more something of a heroic attempt to be different. At the moment only available in 'artikel' form.
3. Design three meets the wishes of people who like a zero `\parindent` and a positive `\parskip`. As just setting these parameters within for instance 'artikel1' will give some unwanted side effects, I decided to repair these in a separate style.

Credits for the visual design go to one real-life designer and a couple of books by designers I consulted. The full story can be found elsewhere.

3.1 User options

As was mentioned above, the new layout of the table of contents has turned out to be somewhat controversial. So, in order to ensure wider acceptance of these styles I have incorporated a switch that will restore the old layout. Just specify the oldtoc option. This is available in designs 1 and 3. Number 2 really insists on being different.

3.2 Option files

Like in the standard styles there exist option files for 10/11/12 point layout. Until now, however, I have managed to get away with using the same option files for both the 'artikel' 'rapport', and 'boek' styles. The option files then have to have some neutral names. Which are at the moment `ntg10`, `ntg11`, and `ntg12`. 'NTG', of course, stands for Nederlandse TeX Gebruikersgroep, i.e., Dutch TeX Users Group.

When doing the 'rapport' styles, I needed to modify the '`titlepag`' option file. Thus there is a Dutch version of that, bearing the name of 'voorwerk' (literal translation: 'frontwork'). Probably the majority of Dutch LaTeX users don't even know that this is the correct term. You're never too old to learn.

With the LaTeX 2_ε version of thes classes the file `voorwerk.sty` has disappeared. It has been turned into the internal option voorwerk, just like `titlpage.sty` has disappeared into the internal option titlepage.